Shri Shringla, the JS (East Asia), Shri Naveen Srivastava from the MEA, and the DGMO, Lt Gen Paramjit Singh Sangha from the Army were present. This mini-CSG had been necessitated by the continuing leaks to the media. The eighth round of deliberations on 6 November was known to the media on 11 November, and the ninth round outcomes of 24 January were already being speculated about in the media on 25 January itself. This had been a recurring headache and a matter of concern as it had the potential to derail the talks. On more than one occasion, the PLA had complained that even before they had had the opportunity to debrief their higher-ups, the news was already on all our TV channels. We had to repeatedly explain to the PLA that the leak was not from the Army and that we are a democracy with a free and open media, and that they would have to bear with us. I reiterated this point in the CSG meeting, adding that if it was of such critical significance, the office of the NSA had all the resources to be able to pinpoint the leak. I am sanguine that the NSA must have looked into it, because there were no more leaks after that.

We got down to discuss the details of the proposal. Was it enough now that they had accepted our baseline of status quo ante, or could we squeeze out a little more? Although the area of North and South Bank was getting resolved, PP-15 and PP-17A would remain pending. And what about the legacy issues of Depsang and Demchok? The deliberations went back and forth. I felt that it was the area of the Fingers that was uppermost in the public imagination—the images of new infrastructure, jetties, boats and above all, the outline map of China on the lakeside. Getting the PLA out of this area and to the East of Finger 8 should be the priority. The only leverage we had was our occupation of the Kailash Range. Realistically speaking, how strong was this lever? Was it strong enough

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